

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 6, 2025

Quirky UMass landmark has another surprise

Cocaine sting puts hotel on Amherst campus in the spotlight

By Brooke Hauser

GLOBE STAFF

AMHERST — The Hotel UMass at the University of Massachusetts Amherst is known for its prime location in the heart of campus, its stark Brutalist architecture, and its prominence as a teaching hotel for students majoring in hospitality and tourism management.

Now it's also drawing attention as one setting in an elaborate cocaine sting.

caine sting.

You won't find that on Tripadvisor, where the hotel is rated best in Amherst with 4 out of 5 stars and billed as being minutes away from downtown, "allowing you to discover the magic of the Pioneer Valley."

But more details around the arrest of LaMar Cook, Governor Maura Healey's former aide in Western Massachusetts, emerged last week in a Springfield courtroom packed

with supporters, spectators, and press.

The investigation began last month after federal authorities seized two suspicious packages in Kentucky addressed to Hotel UMass. Two similar parcels were delivered to the hotel on Sept. 26, according to an arrest report shared with the Globe. When hotel staff noticed the name on the parcels — "Morgan Gordon" — didn't match

the names of any hotel guests, they sent them to the building's loading dock.

On Oct. 24, federal authorities flagged another suspicious UPS package in Kentucky that was seized and searched, and the next day, police launched their sting: A state trooper posing as a UPS driver delivered the package to Springfield's state office building known as the "Little State House."

The story has reminded some of

HOTEL, Page A7

'The square was electric. It was inviting. People would come with their kids and hang out. That's gone.'

PAUL MALVONE, owner of Boston Burger Company



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

Advocates say that closure of area homelessness programs has pushed more people into Davis Square in Somerville.

IN BUSTLING DAVIS SQUARE, AN UNWELCOME CHANGE

Recent surge in homelessness brings violence and open drug use

By Spencer Buell

GLOBE STAFF

SOMERVILLE — Below Davis Square, the outreach center the Somerville Homeless Coalition has used for 40 years is a refuge.

The coffee is hot and a free breakfast awaits, as does help getting into a home.

Above ground, it's often a different story. And as more of the region's homeless show up here, locals say increased violence and drug use are pushing the neighborhood to a breaking point.

"Police are here all the time. People are overdosing. There's needles all over the place. It's not good for the community. It's unacceptable and I'm sick and tired of it," said Clifford, 39, who said he's been home-

less off and on for over a decade, and asked that the Globe not use his last name to protect his privacy. He's now housed in Chelsea, but the Somerville native still spends his days in Davis because it's the place he knows best.

But things have changed in the familiar crossroads. Whether they are housed or not, many who spend time here are confronting what they described as an unprecedented surge in the number of people on the streets, including many who are struggling with mental illness or drug addiction, or both.

"The numbers have increased significantly," said Michael Libby, the homeless coalition's executive director. "The visibility is different than it's ever been."

The scene at Statue Park, the brick plaza

near the Davis MBTA stop, can be unpredictable.

On a recent morning, a dozen or so people huddled in groups. One man, in a T-shirt despite the October chill, writhed and groaned in a wheelchair, scratching a leg covered in sores.

"That's my nephew," said Karolann, who looked on from a few feet away.

She said she had just come from a methadone clinic, and was keeping an eye on him. When he dropped a sweater, she knelt down to pick it up.

"It's hard for drug addicts. We didn't ask for this disease. We just have it," she said.

Karolann, whose last name the Globe is

DAVIS SQUARE, Page A10

Warnings as FAA aims to cut air traffic

Ripple effects could bring major cancellations

By Jaime Moore-Carrillo

GLOBE STAFF

and Globe news services

The Federal Aviation Administration plans to reduce air traffic by 10 percent in 40 "high traffic" markets around the country beginning Friday to reduce pressure on air traffic controllers who are working long hours without pay during the government

shutdown. The unprecedented move would likely affect thousands of flights and reach far beyond the designated airports because of the ripple effects from delays in arrivals and plane connections. FAA Administrator Bryan Bedford said the location of the 40 markets will be disclosed on Thursday.

Boston's Logan Airport is on the list, ABC News reported Wednesday night.

"We are starting to see some evidence that fatigue is building in the system in ways that we feel we need to work towards relieving some of that pressure," Bedford said.

SHUTDOWN, Page A6

SHUTDOWN DAY 37

14

Failed Senate votes

Sept. 19

Date of last House session

594,048

Workers furloughed

35 days

Previous longest shutdown

Democrats find some success across country by going local

By Emma Platoff and Niki Griswold

GLOBE STAFF

With the federal government ground to a halt in Washington, Democrats on Tuesday showed their party has found energy and optimism somewhere else: in city halls, state houses — and, yes, even in an obscure state board that regulates utilities.

There were the centrists who clinched governors' races in New Jersey and Virginia by appealing to voters on both sides. Progressive mayors in Boston and New York won on anti-Trump platforms featuring calls for fare-free buses and no-cost child care. In Pennsylvania, three Democratic Supreme Court justices won 10 more years on the bench; in Georgia, two Democrats earned seats on the state Public Service Commission for the first time in nearly two decades.

Taken together, the results were less about the type of Democrat who is emerging as a meaningful voice for the party, and more about where they are located. Amid the stalemate in Washington and long-simmering anger among rank-and-file Democrats over the party's loss of power, voters on Tuesday showed they were eager for progress at the local level, where the likes of Michelle Wu and Zohran Mamdani can wield real political power.

DEMOCRATS, Page A7

Sticker shock not just on the cars — it's on the loans

By Camilo Fonseca

GLOBE STAFF

QUINCY — Al Chang, 67, pulled up to the Ford dealership in his weathered white pickup truck knowing exactly what he wanted — and how much he wanted to pay for it.

A few hours later, Chang had a financing deal in hand for a new F-350, the base model of which retails for an average of \$52,800. But the six-year loan term — longer than he's ever had — gave Chang pause. The Chatham-based building contractor mused that the vehicle will set him back more than what his clients once might have paid for their homes.

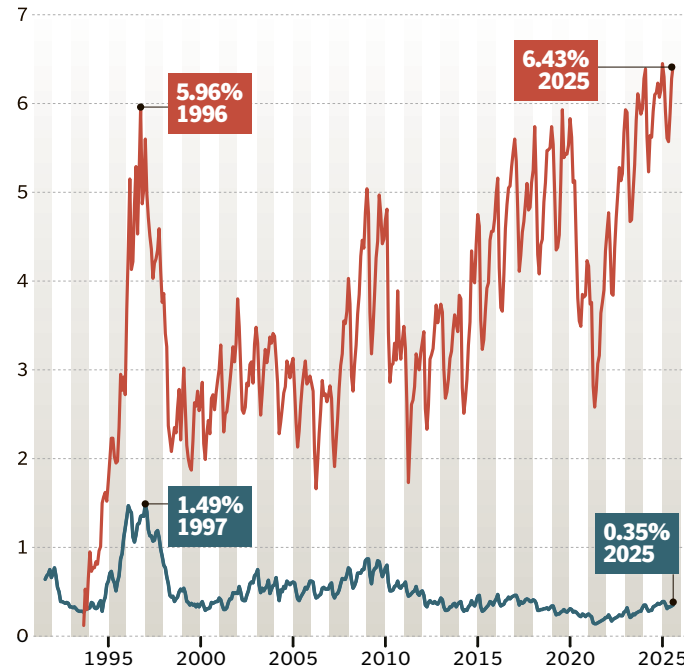
"Going back to the 1980s on Cape Cod, you could buy a

house for \$50,000, \$70,000," he said. "If someone told me that 30 years later, the cost of a vehicle would be the same as the price of a house — it's actually astonishing."

For many Americans, buying and owning a car has become harder than it's been in decades. Buyers are taking on larger loans than ever before, with the average financing for new vehicles rising to \$42,647 in the third quarter, up from \$40,713 at the same time last year. Coupled with eye-watering numbers of delinquencies and repossessions, the car financing market is raising economic warning signs.

The trends are "very alarming," particularly for lower-in-

CAR LOANS, Page A10



Percentage of car loans 60+ days late on payments

National data from 1991 to 2025

Subprime borrowers have credit scores below 670

● Subprime
● Prime

SOURCE: Fitch Ratings
KIRKLAND AN/
GLOBE STAFF



Soften the blow

Thursday: Less windy. High 50-55. Low 34-39.

Friday: A bit warmer. High 53-58. Low 48-53.

Sunrise: 6:24 Sunset: 4:31

Weather and Comics, D5-6.

VOL. 308, NO. 129

*

Suggested retail price
\$4.00

A majority of Supreme Court justices asked skeptical questions about President Trump's use of emergency powers to impose tariffs on imports. A2.

Quincy Mayor Thomas Koch took thousands of dollars in illegal campaign donations, state regulators found, adding to the controversies around him. B1.

Trevor Story explained why he chose to stay with the Sox. C1.

